ASSEMBLY POLLS 2023

party lost the 2018 election only by a whisker—winning 109 seats to the Congress's 114—despite getting more votes. Chouhan was back in the saddle after Jyotiraditya Scindia's defection along with 22 MLAs precipitated the fall of the Kamal Nath-led Congress government in March 2020.

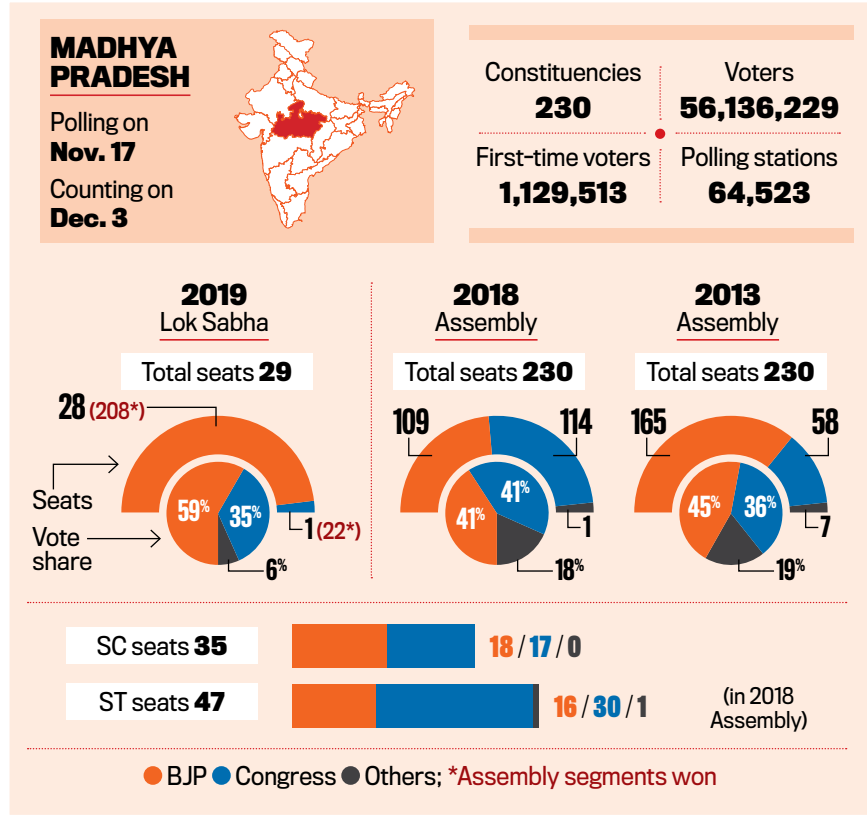
However, the political wind seems to be blowing the other way for Chouhan this election season. For one, the BJP's central leadership is directing the entire show, be it candidate selection or poll strategy. Union ministers Bhupendra Yadav and Ashwini Vaishnaw have been drafted for the election. Most critically for Chouhan, the party has shied away from projecting him as the CM candidate. There are fewer mentions of him in speeches in public meetings, and he is one among the many in whose names votes are being sought. What explains it and how does Chouhan ride this trough?

A DEMON CALLED ANTI-INCUMBENCY

The very distinction of being his party's longest-serving chief minister has made Chouhan a liability, with 16 years of anti-incumbency. And the BJP wants to take no chances as survey after survey predicts a close fight between the Congress and the BJP in MP. The CM's own stock seems to be down. In the India Today Political Stock Exchange (PSE) findings released three months ago, 40 per cent of the respondents did say they were very satisfied with the government's performance, but 27 per cent said they were satisfied only to an extent while another 32 per cent said they were not satisfied at all. In another data set on the CM's performance, 40 per cent said they were fully satisfied, 25 per cent said they were somewhat satisfied and 34 per cent said they were not satisfied at all. In a comparison of Chouhan and Congress's Nath as the best candidate for CM, Chouhan scored over his rival by a mere percentage point—37 per cent as opposed to 36 per cent for Nath.

Based on this feedback, the BJP has decided to neutralise anti-incumbency by downplaying the very factor causing it—its four-time chief minister in the state. The party, therefore, has been strategically suppressing Chouhan's contribution in the poll narrative. Unlike for the previous election, when Chouhan led a single Jan Ashirwad Yatra, this time there were five parallel yatras, with Chouhan as a participant and not a leader. Individual leaders instead were assigned the responsibility of each yatra, whose objective was to galvanise party workers ahead of the polls, something the party leaders felt could be better achieved without Chouhan as the main focus.

In another strategy to broad-base leadership options, the party is fielding eight national-level leaders, among them Union ministers Narendra Singh Tomar, Faggan Singh Kulaste and Prahlad Patel, besides MPs Riti Pathak, Rakesh Singh, Rao Uday Pratap Singh and Rakesh Singh, and national general secretary Kailash Vijayvargiya. Party strategists feel that in



THE CM'S REPORT CARD

STRENGTHS

- The biggest brand for the BJP in MP, tried and tested
- Gains from the BJP's famed organisational set-up right down to the booth level
- Can pack in the hours, on the campaign trail perpetually

CHALLENGES

- Sixteen-plus years of anti-incumbency
- Opposition from within the BJP leadership
- Increasing control by central leadership leaves him with less say in elections